

Yutong (Max) Zhu

Division of the Social Sciences, University of Chicago

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EDUCATION

University of Chicago

Ph.D., Sociology

Chicago, IL

Expected 2031

University of Chicago

M.A., Computational Social Science

Chicago, IL

Jun 2025

Carnegie Mellon University

B.S. (University Honors), Computer Science;

Additional Major in History

Pittsburgh, PA

May 2022

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

≡ indicates equal contribution and shared first authorship.

[3] Zehan Li, **Yutong Zhu**, Siyang Wu, Honglin Bao, James A. Evans. “Narrative Flattening: How Post-Training Compresses Thematic, Affective, and Stylistic Variation in LLM Fiction.” **Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP) 2026**. [Preprint].

[2] Peiqi Sui[≡], **Yutong Zhu**[≡], Tianyi Cheng, Peter West, Richard Jean So, Hoyt Long, Ari Holtzman. “Spoiler Alert: Narrative Forecasting as a Metric for Tension in LLM Storytelling.” **Conference on Language Modeling (COLM) 2026**. [Preprint].

[1] **Zhu, Yutong**. Explaining Gendered Language Through Embedding Approximation: How “Stupid” Became a Man’s Word. *Social Forces*, 2026, article soag103 (Advance Access). [DOI]

PAPERS UNDER REVIEW

[1] Rochelle Terman, Shilin Jia, **Yutong Zhu**, and James Evans. The Nations in Our Minds: Historical Representations of Countries in Google Books. In submission.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

[1] **Zhu, Yutong**, Tianyi Zhang, Junsol Kim, Aaron Schein, and James Evans. Language models encode the structure of a belief system and flatten it at their output. *Manuscript in preparation*.

PRESENTATIONS

Explaining Gendered Language Through Embedding Approximation: How “Stupid” Became a Man’s Word

- American Sociological Association (ASA) Annual Meeting 2025, Section Session

The Nations in Our Minds: Historical Representations of Countries in Google Books

- International Studies Association (ISA) Annual Convention 2025, Regular Session

Between Min and Zu: Ethnonym and National Narrative in Post-Imperial China

- Midwest Conference on Asian Affairs (MCAA) 2024, Regular Session

HONORS & AWARDS

University Scholar Full-Tuition Scholarship, University of Chicago, 2023–2025

Ludwig Schaefer Award for Outstanding Achievement in History, Carnegie Mellon University, 2022

Dietrich College Senior Honors Fellowship, Carnegie Mellon University, 2021

TEACHING
EXPERIENCE

University of Chicago

- Large-Scale Computing for the Social Sciences (Spring 2025), Dr. Jon Clindaniel, Dr. Fabricio Vasselai
- Perspectives on Computational Modeling (Winter 2025), Dr. Zhao Wang

PROFESSIONAL
EXPERIENCE

Journal of Asian Studies

Editorial Assistant (Part-Time)

Remote

Mar 2023 – Jun 2025

Stellar Cyber

Data Engineer

San Jose, CA

Jun 2022 – Feb 2023

SKILLS

Methods: Data Management, Quantitative & Qualitative Research, Academic Writing, Data Analysis & Pipeline, Machine Learning, NLP

Technical: Python, C, Java, SPARQL, SQL, Kubernetes, Git; Adobe Photoshop, Illustrator, InDesign

Languages: Mandarin (native), French (intermediate), Uzbek (elementary)

REFERENCES

James Evans

Max Palevsky Professor of Sociology & Data Science

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John Levi Martin

Florence Borchert Bartling Professor, Sociology

University of Chicago

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